

10-22-2024 MCS Board Meeting and Work Session

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8ZuW8AZkwY4
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Municipal Meeting Summary Report

Board/Council Name: Muncie Community Schools Board of Education

Meeting Date: October 22, 2024

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

- **Session Type & Topic:** 00:07:16 Operations Fund Work Session & Five-Year Comprehensive Financial Plan.
- **Summary of Discussion:** Chief Financial Officer Brad DeRome, assisted by Dr. Chuck Reynolds, led a deep-dive work session regarding the district's operations fund, its companion rainy day fund, and the 5-year look-ahead financial plan (projected through 2028). Key details included:
 - **Spending & Revenue Realities:** Operational spending averages approximately \$13 million annually. The district faces ongoing challenges due to the expiration of protected tax caps/waivers and incremental financing after 2022. Revenue is currently sustained primarily through education fund transfers (up to the statutory 15% limit), property taxes, and increased interest income.
 - **Major Expense Drivers:** A pie chart of the operations budget revealed that maintenance, custodial, and building contracts (specifically with outside vendor SSC, representing 32% of spending and roughly \$336,000/month with escalator

clauses) and transportation are the largest cost centers. Property and casualty insurance also spiked by \$320,000 in January 2024, placing severe strain on the operations fund.

- **Baker Tilly Financial Indicators:** Representatives from Baker Tilly presented fiscal health indicators. While indicators like net assessed valuation (AV) growth, fund balances, and tax rates received green lights, circuit breaker losses received a red light, with the district losing roughly 48<U+2013>50% of its property tax levy to tax caps.
- **Future Strategies:** The board discussed potential “budget levers,” including exploring alternative property/casualty insurance quotes, continuing transportation route efficiency, utilizing general obligation bonds for short-term facility/utility upgrades (such as heating/cooling at the Fieldhouse and LED lighting), and aggressively transferring education fund surpluses into the rainy day fund.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding officer officially called the regular meeting to order following the work session [01:07:42](#).
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Mr. Heer, Mrs. Barnes-Griffin, Mr. Irvin, Mr. Lunsford, Mrs. Washburn.
 - **Absent:** Mr. Williams.
 - **Presiding Officer:** Not explicitly stated by name, but leading the meeting.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with a moment of silence followed by the Pledge of Allegiance [01:07:43](#).
- **Approval of Minutes:** *(Not explicitly detailed in the transcript text).*

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- [01:18:37](#) **Financial Report & Monthly Snapshot**
 - **Presenter:** Brad DeRome, CFO.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** CFO DeRome presented the September financial snapshot. The district received \$3.9 million from the state basic grant (with a 12-month estimate over \$47 million). Total cash balance across all funds was just over \$29 million at the end of September, projected to exceed \$30 million by December. Additionally, \$6.1 million in General Obligation bonds were successfully sold at 3.67% interest for a one-year payback to fund upcoming parking lot, Fieldhouse,

and stadium restroom projects. The state loan balance has been reduced to \$8.4 million.

- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [01:19:47](#).
- **01:20:05 Administrator Compensation & Contracts**
 - **Presenter:** Dr. Chuck Reynolds / Board Committee.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The compensation committee recommended raises for administrators based on performance ratings (highly effective/effective), mirroring the ~2% raises given to teachers and support staff. Additionally, contracts for Mr. DeRome and Dr. Bell were reviewed, renewed, and adjusted to reflect the approved percentage raise.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [01:21:56](#).
- **01:22:00 2025 Employee Medical Insurance Renewal**
 - **Presenter:** Brad DeRome, CFO.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The district recommended keeping Anthem as its medical carrier for 2025 with **zero increase** in medical, dental, or vision premiums for employees for the second consecutive year. The self-funded insurance plan maintains a fund balance of over \$3.3 million. Contributing factors include a younger, less experienced employee demographic (50% under 5 years of service) leading to lower claims, alongside utilization of the free employee health clinic. HRA and HSA contribution amounts will remain identical to the previous year.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [01:24:52](#).
- **01:26:02 Permission to Advertise Additional Appropriations**
 - **Presenter:** Brad DeRome, CFO.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Request for permission to advertise an additional appropriation hearing for the November board meeting. The request seeks \$400,000 for the rainy day fund and \$2.6 million for the education fund. CFO DeRome clarified that this does not increase tax rates, levies, or taxes; it simply grants statutory spending authority for the final months of the calendar year using existing cash balances on hand.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [01:27:16](#).

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- No members of the public signed up or spoke during the open public comment period [01:03:39, 01:15:03].

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - **Dr. Reynolds' Superintendent Update:**

- The annual Strategic Plan Report (mandated by House Bill 1315) was distributed to key stakeholders, the state superintendent, and staff, and posted on the district website.
 - The quarterly district newsletter was published to enhance family and community engagement.
 - Principal Evan Shroyer (EWA) was recognized as an outstanding alumnus by Ivy Tech Muncie/Henry County.
 - Athletic updates: Muncie Central football secured a win and advanced to sectionals at Logansport; cross-country teams performed strongly, with the boys' team and three female individuals advancing to Regionals.
 - Upcoming student events include middle school choir and band concerts, high school Halloween band concerts, and student art displays integrated into the Muncie Art Walk.
- **Adjournment:** The meeting was officially adjourned by voice vote [01:29:10](#).

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